When Your Mind Jumps to Conclusions

What am I being asked to believe — and what supports it?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1, especially its closing instruction; **Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.49**. Epictetus asks us to examine impressions and what is up to us. Marcus separates what is reported from what we add. An impression is how something appears; assent accepts what it presents as true.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary example of a quick conclusion. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	**Discuss · 40**	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	Test a message with no reply	**The questions below**	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. An important message has no reply. What do you know, and what might your mind add?
2. Which impressions feel most convincing before you examine them? Why?
3. What judgment or intention belongs to you, and what depends on someone else?
4. What evidence would justify accepting, rejecting, or leaving a conclusion unsettled?
5. If your first judgment stands after examination, what did the practice accomplish?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Test one impression. When certainty or urgency arrives, name the impression, separate what you know from what you infer, and decide what the grounds support. The judgment may stand, change, or stay unsettled. If you notice only afterward, you can still reopen it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What supports that?" Ask it of reassuring interpretations too. The Fundamental Rule identifies your judgment and intention; another person's response still deserves care.

NOTES

When Wanting Turns Into Needing

Can I pursue this seriously without making a good life depend on getting it?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 2 and 4. Desire and aversion promise getting or escaping something. At the baths, Epictetus's governing aim is to preserve sound choice. Preferred indifferents such as health and security deserve care; virtue determines whether we use them well.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite members to notice a preference that feels like a requirement. A general example is enough.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional January observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Preference or requirement?	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What does something you want promise to give you — or protect you from?
2. How can you tell when a preference becomes something that must happen?
3. If the external goal stays the same, what changes when character governs the pursuit?
4. Can an unwanted outcome bring a real loss without making living well impossible?
5. Once the facts are settled, what would willingness to meet them mean without approving them?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Prefer without requiring. Choose one recurring want. Name its practical value, the condition you have attached to living well, and what stays worth wanting either way. When the demand returns, ask: **"Am I preferring this, or requiring it?"**

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Necessary for what?" Separate an actual practical need from a claim about the possibility of a good life. Allow disappointment and difficult answers.

NOTES

Knowing What to Do—and Doing It

What does this situation call for from me?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 30; Musonius Rufus, Lecture 5, "Which Is More Effective, Theory or Practice?" Relationships help identify responsibilities; Musonius puts practice ahead of explanation. An appropriate action is one you can reasonably justify. If obstructed, a different response may fit.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask members to notice one responsibility they understand but find hard to carry out. Nobody needs a journal or prior lessons.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional February observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Give a virtue an action	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In an ordinary responsibility, what makes an action fitting rather than merely convenient?
2. How does being a friend, colleague, parent, or neighbor clarify your part?
3. When someone else fails in their role, what changes about yours?
4. If your plan is blocked, what concrete action could express the virtue now required?
5. Looking across judgment, desire, and action, what small practice is worth retaining?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give it an action. Choose one recurring responsibility. Identify what matters, decide **"I will ___ because ___,"** and take the next step. Repeat when it recurs; adapt when circumstances change. Assess your reasons and follow-through, not others' cooperation.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What would that look like?" Turn "be patient" or "be responsible" into conduct someone could describe. A useful answer may include a refusal or boundary.

NOTES

Before You Judge Someone

What did this person do — and what have I added?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 45 and 43. The first passage separates description from judgments that need further knowledge. The second acknowledges a brother's injustice while recalling their relationship. A fuller perspective must be true and relevant; it need not excuse misconduct or restore trust.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Ask for anonymous examples. Members may use the fictional case instead of a personal conflict.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Ground rules; no identifying details	Aloud, together	A colleague misses a deadline	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. A colleague misses an agreed deadline. What is established, and what remains uncertain?
2. When does a judgment about conduct become a verdict about the whole person?
3. What other true and relevant perspective would help you understand this conflict fairly?
4. Can a justified grievance acquire an additional verdict that payback would be good?
5. What remains owed to a fellow human being when an adverse judgment is justified?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Separate conduct from verdict. When judging someone, describe the conduct, name the further conclusion, and examine its grounds. Recall a relevant relationship or shared humanity without inventing a reassuring motive. Keep warranted criticism; revise what exceeds the evidence.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Which judgment are we examining?" Distinguish misconduct, motive, personal worth, and payback. Understanding a person does not settle what response justice requires.

NOTES

Making Room for Other People

Whose good is missing from what I want?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 48.1–3; Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 5.6. Seneca links friendship with shared interests. Marcus separates helping from keeping account of what others owe. We examine whom our desires include and what return we require.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite members to notice a shared decision where their preference affects someone else. Include a reading link; preparation is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional April observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Widen a meeting-time preference	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In a shared choice, whose interests do you include — and whose are easy to overlook?
2. What would you hope for an overlooked person if someone close to you were in their place?
3. How could taking those interests seriously change what you want, even if your preference remains?
4. When you contribute, what recognition are you waiting for before it feels worthwhile?
5. If someone declines your help, can their welfare remain important without their compliance?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give the want a wider aim. Before one shared choice, name your preference and an overlooked legitimate interest, then finish: **"I want ___ while taking ___ seriously."** Keep that concern without praise or agreement. No extra good deed is required.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Who else is affected?" Include someone who bears a cost without being present. Fair concern includes your own legitimate needs; it does not guarantee a compromise.

NOTES

Doing Your Part

What contribution is mine to make?

READING

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.12 and 10.4. Marcus directs attention to communal benefit and to correction that shows an error without hostility. Justice gives us reasons to seek fitting contributions as well as examine how we act and speak.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite members to notice a small unmet need in a shared undertaking. No promise to volunteer is expected.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional May observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Turn a need into a bounded contribution	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What useful contribution might go undone because nobody has been asked?
2. How do role, ability, and existing responsibilities help determine your part?
3. What would make the proposed contribution honest, fair, and useful to the people affected?
4. If correction is needed, how can you make the request clear without adding contempt?
5. What have fairer judgments, wider concern, and just action taught you about living with others?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Seek one fitting contribution. In a setting you already belong to, notice a real need, check your role and limits, and complete one bounded contribution. Ask before helping when consent matters. Learn and adapt if the help misses its mark; appreciation is not the measure.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Does this fit the actual need?" Test the contribution from the recipient's side. Service may involve asking, correcting, referring, or stepping back.

NOTES

When a Difficulty Becomes a Disaster

What is the difficulty — and what am I predicting it means?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 13.4–12; **Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 4**. Seneca examines anticipated troubles and the evidence for them. Epictetus prepares for familiar obstacles while preserving sound choice. Preparation acknowledges a possibility; it does not establish that the feared event will happen.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary worry about a task or conversation. Personal crises need not become discussion examples.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; passing is fine	Selected passages aloud	A difficult presentation: facts vs. predictions	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before a difficult presentation, which problems are known and which are predictions?
2. How do discomfort, uncertainty, or embarrassment affect the confidence you give a judgment?
3. What evidence would support the feared conclusion — and what would weaken it?
4. How does rehearsing one realistic obstacle differ from repeatedly imagining disaster?
5. If the difficulty is real, what remains yours to judge without minimizing the risk?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name the difficulty precisely. In one pressured situation, state the present facts, name the prediction or evaluation added, and decide what the evidence supports. You may also rehearse one likely obstacle and a sound response. Leave unsupported predictions open.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is happening now?" Separate current evidence from a future story. A more cheerful forecast needs evidence too; reasonable precautions can proceed under uncertainty.

NOTES

What Am I Trying Never to Face?

What am I treating as something that must never happen?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 2; Seneca, *Letters* 18.5–8. Epictetus redirects aversion toward misusing our own choice. Seneca rehearses simple living to examine dependence on comfort and wealth. This modern adaptation uses a modest, safe inconvenience to inspect what we think we need.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Say the topic includes fear, comfort, and dependence. Nobody must disclose a loss or undertake discomfort. Bring the reading links.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Welcome; anyone may pass	Aloud, together	The questions below	Test a small supposed necessity	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What inconvenience do you work hard to prevent? What would facing it seem to mean?
2. When does sensible avoidance become a demand for complete protection from difficulty?
3. What might going briefly without a convenience reveal that thinking alone misses?
4. How can knowing life is finite clarify what is worth wanting without making us gloomy?
5. In difficulty, what misuse of your own choice deserves more concern than discomfort?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Examine one aversion. Name what you want to avoid and why escape seems necessary. If suitable, try one harmless inconvenience, such as setting aside entertainment while waiting, and notice what it reveals about dependence. A recent unavoidable one works as well; no endurance contest is needed.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What are we testing?" Keep the focus on valuation. Choose ordinary discomfort that fits health and responsibilities; there is no need for deprivation or proof of toughness.

NOTES

Doing the Right Thing When It Is Hard

What responsibility deserves my steadiness now?

READING

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 5.1 and 5.9. Marcus recalls his work as a human being and urges a return to sound principles after falling short. Courage sustains fitting conduct through difficulty; changing the method may help preserve the responsibility.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite a modest example, such as a needed conversation. No dramatic courage required.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional August observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rehearse one difficult next step	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What makes a responsibility worth continuing when motivation fades?
2. When is persistence fitting, and when do rest, help, or a changed plan better serve it?
3. What needs saying in a difficult conversation, and how can you say it fairly?
4. After a mistake, what separates renewed effort from excuses or self-condemnation?
5. How have examining threats and aversions helped you act when the right thing has a cost?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Take the next fitting step. Choose one worthwhile responsibility and take its next concrete action when the occasion comes. If blocked or mistaken, correct what you can and choose the next step. Steadiness can include changing course; assess conduct, not applause.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Steady toward what?" Test the purpose before encouraging perseverance. Courage remains answerable to wisdom, justice, and temperance.

NOTES

Before You Give In

What is this pleasure promising — and do I have grounds to agree?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 34 and *Discourses* 4.12.1–5. Epictetus advises delay and considering pleasure's aftermath. His account of attention also includes play and song. We apply these ideas to examining a compelling promise; enjoyment can still be a reasonable choice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the reading links. Invite an ordinary example: scrolling, shopping, or another episode. No private habit needs to be disclosed.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; no confessions required	Aloud, together	Test the promise of one more episode	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. When an urge says "one more," what exactly is it asking you to believe?
2. What would a brief delay let you examine that the urge leaves out?
3. How can you consider the aftermath without assuming all enjoyment leads to regret?
4. What captures your attention repeatedly, and how does that shape what seems worth choosing?
5. When might a limit chosen in advance help judgment — and when should you reconsider it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Examine the promise. Pause in one recurring temptation, name the promised benefit, and consider the choice now and afterward. Accept, revise, or decline on grounds you can explain; an advance limit can help you remember them. Pleasure alone does not settle it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is the claim?" Find the judgment inside "I need this now." Passing on pleasure is not automatically progress; more careful examination is.

NOTES

How Much Is Enough?

What would satisfy the need — and why do I still want more?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 15; Seneca, *Letters* 23.1–8. Epictetus's banquet image trains moderation in receiving and waiting for externals. Seneca directs joy toward sound purpose and conduct. We examine dependence on more and what we are learning to value.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite members to notice an expanding "enough": possessions, praise, convenience, or certainty. Nobody needs to discuss finances.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional October observation	Selected passages aloud	The questions below	Define enough in one area	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In one area of life, what would enough provide? What keeps moving the threshold?
2. At the banquet, what changes when you receive your share without treating the table as yours?
3. How could simplifying one convenience reveal whether you depend on it?
4. What gladness comes from sound judgment or goodwill rather than getting another external reward?
5. How can you appreciate ordinary advantages without making them conditions of living well?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name enough. Choose one recurring want and state what would reasonably serve its purpose. When the threshold expands, examine what "more" promises; simplifying one small area can test the dependence. Notice what remains worth welcoming; no cheerful mood is required.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Enough for what purpose?" Needs differ with circumstances and responsibilities. Examine the reason for the threshold rather than ranking people by how little they own.

NOTES

A Practice You Can Keep

What deserves a lasting place in the way I live?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 20.1–5; **Epictetus, *Discourses* 3.2.1–5**. Seneca seeks agreement between principles and conduct. Epictetus distinguishes training in desire, action, and assent. Use these fields to find a practice that helps in a real recurring situation; keep the commitment sustainable.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite one remembered practice or question worth retaining. Notes are optional; newcomers may choose something useful from tonight's discussion.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 20	Close · 10
Welcome; recognize shared learning	Aloud, together	The questions below	Build a one-sentence practice rule	One contribution each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which practice helped you notice or do something differently in ordinary life?
2. What difficulty remains, and which field — judgment, desire, or action — needs attention?
3. When two legitimate responsibilities compete, how can one ethical standard guide different responses?
4. What would make your chosen practice realistic on a crowded day?
5. What did someone in this group help you notice that you might have missed alone?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give practice a place. Finish: **"When ___, I will use ___ to ___."** Choose one useful practice and an ordinary cue. Try it, then review whether it fits the situation and your responsibilities. If you miss an occasion, resume at the next. Add more only when there is a reason.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What changed in the example?" Seek evidence without demanding improvement. Mixed results can clarify what to keep, adapt, or let go.

NOTES